



Planning Session

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Learning Objectives

At the end of this session, participants will be able to:

- Explain why some plans fail and others succeed
- Recall the key differences between sticking to a plan and adapting a plan
- Demonstrate the effectiveness of a plan or decide on another steps
- Illustrate how to make decisions about sticking or adapting a plan

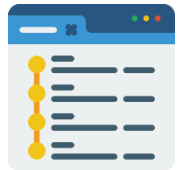
Introduction

Planning is a core leadership skill that goes beyond setting goals and timelines. It also includes understanding how to prepare for uncertainty through approaches such as scenario planning, which helps in anticipating different possible outcomes. Effective planning is not a fixed process, but a dynamic one that evolves based on execution, feedback, and changing conditions. This raises an important leadership perspective: knowing when to continue following a plan and when to adjust or change it based on what the situation requires.

Planning Definition

Planning is the process of setting objectives and determining the best course of action to achieve them.

It involves defining a clear vision, aligning it with a mission, and translating both into structured steps and strategies. In leadership and organizational contexts, planning serves as a **roadmap** that guides decisions, prioritizes efforts, and ensures effective use of resources to achieve desired impact.



Rational Planning Model

The Rational Planning Model is a structured framework that explains how to build an effective plan in a logical and step-by-step way. It shows us how to move from understanding a situation and setting clear objectives, to generating alternatives, selecting the best option, and finally implementing and evaluating the plan. This model helps in turning ideas and vision into a clear, organized, and actionable plan that can be realistically executed

1. Identifying Goals & Objectives

This step focuses on defining what the plan aims to achieve by setting clear goals and specific objectives that guide all future actions. It ensures that the plan has a clear direction and measurable outcomes from the beginning.



Example:

While shaping a Media vision, defining a clear goal like improving design quality, then translating it into a measurable objective such as creating a unified visual identity during the term.

2. Data Collection & Situation Analysis

This step involves gathering and analyzing information about the current situation, including team strengths, weaknesses, available resources, and challenges. It ensures that the plan is based on real understanding rather than assumptions.



Example:

When building a Logistics plan, observing issues in previous events and using them to understand current challenges. Can be done by **SWOT Analysis**:

S – Strengths: The internal positive factors that give an advantage. In this section, we write everything that can be used as a power or support in achieving the goal.

W – Weaknesses: The internal limitations or areas that need improvement. In this section, we write the factors that might slow down or weaken the execution of the plan.

O – Opportunities: The external positive factors that can be used to support the plan. In this section, we write anything external that can be used to our advantage.

T – Threats: The external challenges or risks that may negatively affect the plan. In this section, we write anything outside our control that may create difficulties or risks.

3. Generating Alternatives

This step focuses on creating different possible approaches to achieve the objectives in order to ensure flexibility in planning and avoid limiting the solution to one idea.



Example:

While planning a Marketing direction, thinking of multiple ways to increase reach such as campaigns, collaborations, or content strategies.

4. Evaluating Alternatives

Each alternative is analyzed based on feasibility, resources, and expected impact to determine the most suitable option for implementation.

Example:

While shaping an External Relations plan, comparing partnership approaches based on feasibility and available resources.



5. Selecting the Best Alternative

This step involves choosing the most effective and realistic option based on evaluation, ensuring that it aligns with objectives and available resources.

Example:

In structuring an HR system, selecting a follow-up method that balances consistency and flexibility.



6. Implementation

This step focuses on turning the selected plan into actionable steps by defining roles, tasks, timelines, and workflows to ensure proper execution.

Example:

A Logistics approach may execute the plan by defining responsibilities for each event phase, scheduling preparation timelines, and tracking task completion.



7. Monitoring & Evaluation

This step ensures continuous follow-up of the plan to track progress, identify issues, and make necessary adjustments to improve performance.

Example:

A Secretary General system can be assessed by reviewing documentation quality, workflow efficiency, and overall organizational stability



Rational Planning

Scenario Planning

A strategic planning approach used to explore different possible future situations and prepare flexible responses for each one. Instead of relying on a single expected outcome, it focuses on understanding multiple “what could happen” scenarios in order to reduce uncertainty and improve decision-making. It helps in building a plan that is adaptable and capable of handling changes in real-life conditions.

Types of Scenarios:

Scenario planning is usually based on three main types of situations:

- **Best-case scenario:** when everything goes better than expected
- **Worst-case scenario:** when major challenges or problems occur
- **Most likely scenario:** the realistic and expected situation



How It Works in Planning?

Different possible situations are identified first, then each scenario is analyzed separately to understand its impact on the plan. After that, flexible actions or responses are prepared to deal with each possibility effectively.

This ensures that the plan is not rigid and can adapt to different outcomes.



Key Points

Scenario Planning:

1. Thinking about different possible futures
2. Preparing for uncertainty
3. Building multiple scenarios (best, worst, most likely)
4. Making the plan more flexible and adaptable

Why Leaders Resist Change in Planning

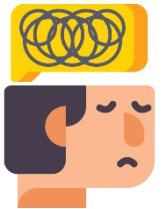
In leadership and planning processes, resistance to change is common. Even leaders may hesitate to change existing plans or approaches due to several psychological and organizational reasons that affect decision-making and implementation.

1. Fear of the Unknown

Leaders may resist change because new plans involve uncertainty. Moving from a known strategy to a new one can feel risky, especially when outcomes are not fully predictable.

Example:

Local Exchange Officer might avoid a new exchange promotion strategy because participation results are uncertain.



2. Comfort with Existing Systems

Leaders often become attached to current methods because they are familiar and have worked before. This creates resistance to changing something that already feels “safe.”

Example:

HR Chairperson may stick to the same follow-up approach simply because it has worked before.



3. Lack of Confidence in Change Success

If leaders are not fully confident that the new plan will succeed, they may avoid taking the risk of change. This is especially true in complex or high-pressure environments.

Example:

External Relations Chairperson may delay new partnership strategies due to lack of confidence in expected outcomes



4. Poor Communication or Lack of Clarity

When the benefits or details of change are not clearly communicated, leaders may resist because they do not fully understand the purpose or impact of the new plan.

Example:

Logistics and Organizing Chairperson may resist a new organizing method if its workflow and benefits are not clearly explained.



5. Emotional Attachment to Previous Plans

Leaders may feel personally connected to their original plans or strategies, especially if they invested time and effort in creating them. Changing them may feel like abandoning their work.

Example:

Media and Publications Chairperson might hesitate to redesign the visual identity because of attachment to the current style,



Key Points

Resistance to change in planning is not always about rejecting improvement, but often about uncertainty, emotional attachment, and lack of confidence in new approaches. Understanding these reasons helps leaders become more flexible and open to better strategies.

Why Plans Fail?

Lack of clear ownership & accountability

- No clear roles and responsibilities
- Tasks may be ignored or duplicated
- Lack of ownership slows execution



No regular follow-up or tracking

- No continuous monitoring of progress
- Plan loses momentum over time
- Issues are not detected early



Too many priorities without focus

- Everything is treated as important
- Lack of prioritization
- Leads to confusion and overload



Lack of resources (Time, Capacity, Support)

- Limited time or team availability
- Lack of needed skills or tools
- Workload exceeds capacity



Weak leadership buy-in or team engagement

- Lack of commitment from leaders
- Team not involved or motivated
- Low ownership of the plan



Plans are not connected to each other

- Vision, mission, and actions are not aligned
- Different parts work separately
- Leads to inefficiency and confusion



Lack of clear system for execution

- No clear workflow or structure
- No defined steps or timeline
- Plan remains theoretical



Key Points

Why Plans Fail?

1. Lack of clear ownership & accountability
2. No regular follow-up or tracking
3. Too many priorities with no clear focus
4. Lack of resources (time, capacity, support)
5. Weak leadership buy-in & team engagement
6. Plans are not aligned or connected
7. No clear execution system

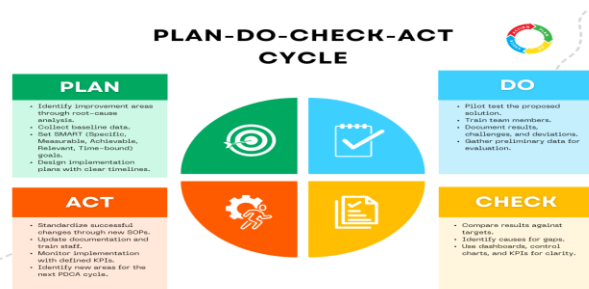
Sticking vs Adapting a Plan

Sticking to the Plan (Persistence)

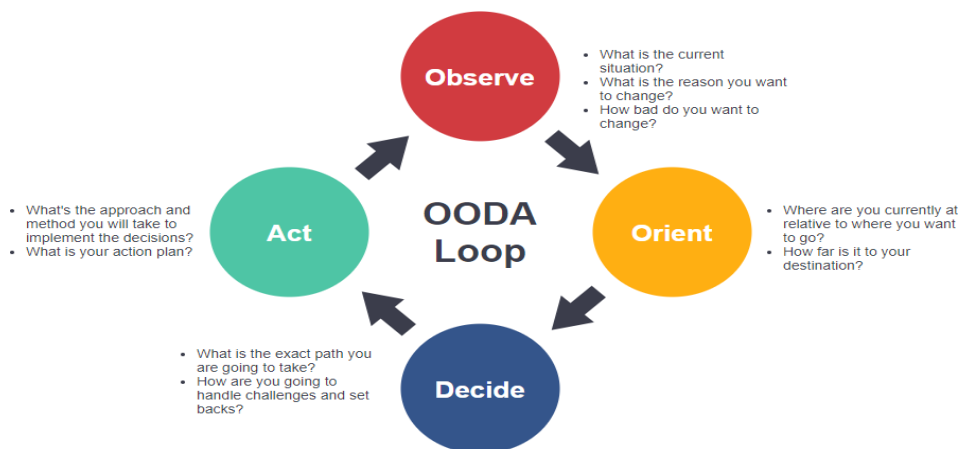
Effective planning in leadership does not only depend on creating a plan, but also on maintaining commitment to it over time. In organizational behavior, persistence refers to continuing a chosen course of action despite challenges or delayed results. Research by Edwin Locke and Gary Latham highlights that goal commitment and consistent effort are essential for achieving performance outcomes. This suggests that leaders should stick to their plans when goals are clear, meaningful, and when sufficient time has not yet passed to evaluate results, as early changes may prevent long-term success.

Adapting the Plan (Adjustment & Learning)

At the same time, effective leadership requires the ability to adapt based on feedback and changing circumstances. The W. Edwards Deming PDCA Cycle (Plan–Do–Check–Act) demonstrates that after implementing a plan, leaders must assess results and adjust their actions accordingly. This reflects that planning is an ongoing and iterative process rather than a fixed one.



Similarly, the OODA Loop developed by John Boyd emphasizes that effective decision-making requires continuous observation, interpretation, and adjustment in response to changing conditions.



Balancing Between Both Approaches

From a project management perspective, the Project Management Institute emphasizes that successful execution depends on both disciplined implementation and continuous monitoring and adjustment. Therefore, sticking to a plan supports consistency and long-term achievement, while adapting a plan supports flexibility and improvement. Effective leaders, particularly chairpersons, must balance both approaches by sustaining effort when progress requires time, and making informed adjustments when evidence indicates that change is necessary.



Key Points

Sticking means continuing the plan with patience and consistency when it still needs time to show results.

Adapting means adjusting the plan based on feedback or changing conditions to improve outcomes.

Good leadership is knowing when to persist and when to adjust.

How to Adapt

Adapting a plan is the process of making **intentional and informed adjustments** to actions, strategies, or timelines based on feedback, performance results, or environmental changes. In leadership, adaptation is considered a key component of effective decision-making because it allows teams to respond to reality rather than rigidly following initial assumptions.



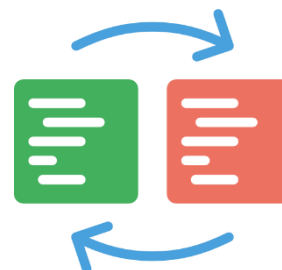
Adaptation requires three core elements:

- Continuous monitoring of progress
- Critical evaluation of what is working and what is not
- Willingness to modify methods without losing sight of the overall goal

For a chairperson, adaptation may include redistributing tasks within the team, changing communication strategies, or modifying deadlines to improve efficiency. Importantly, adaptation is not a reaction to failure, but a **strategic response to improve outcomes based on evidence**.

How to Change

Change refers to a **fundamental shift in direction, strategy, or structure** rather than small adjustments. Unlike adaptation, which improves an existing plan, change often involves replacing the current approach with a new one due to its ineffectiveness or misalignment with goals.



In leadership contexts, change requires:

- Recognition that the current approach is no longer effective
- Clear decision-making regarding the new direction
- Communication and alignment with the team to ensure smooth transition
- Implementation of a new strategy or framework

For a chairperson, managing change is critical because it affects team stability, motivation, and performance. Therefore, change should be **deliberate, evidence-based, and clearly justified**, not emotional or impulsive.

When to Hold On

Holding on to a plan means maintaining commitment to the original strategy despite challenges, delays, or lack of immediate results. In leadership, this concept is strongly linked to **discipline, consistency, and persistence**.



A leader should hold on when:

- The timeline is too short to fairly evaluate outcomes
- The team is still building consistency in execution
- Challenges are expected as part of the process
- The goal remains relevant, valuable, and aligned with priorities

Holding on is important because many initiatives fail not due to poor planning, but due to **premature abandonment**. Effective leaders understand that meaningful results often require sustained effort over time.

When to Shift

Shifting refers to a **strategic decision to move away from the current plan** when evidence shows that it is no longer effective or optimal. It is different from emotional quitting because it is based on analysis rather than frustration.



A shift is justified when:

- There is consistent lack of progress despite strong execution
- External conditions have changed significantly (resources, time, priorities)
- The original assumptions behind the plan are no longer valid
- A more effective alternative approach is identified

For a chairperson, shifting is a critical leadership skill because it ensures that effort and resources are not wasted on ineffective strategies. It reflects **strategic flexibility and situational awareness**.



Key Points

Effective leadership in planning is about knowing when to stay consistent and when to adjust. Holding on to a plan is important when progress needs time and execution is still in process. Adapting or changing becomes necessary when results show the current approach is not effective or conditions have changed. The key skill is making decisions based on evidence rather than emotions.



Nice to know

Plans fail more often from execution than from design

Even well-designed plans can fail when implementation is weak, accountability is unclear, or follow-up is inconsistent. Research in project management shows that execution quality is often the main differentiator between successful and failed plans.

Conclusion

Planning is a continuous leadership process that involves setting objectives, analyzing the current situation, making decisions, and ensuring execution and improvement over time. It

starts with clear goals and evaluating alternatives to choose the most effective course of action, but its success depends on implementation, monitoring, and continuous refinement.

Effective planning requires both structure and flexibility. Structured models provide direction, while tools like scenario planning help leaders prepare for uncertainty. Despite that, plans can fail due to weak execution, lack of accountability, limited resources, or poor alignment within teams.

Leadership effectiveness lies in balancing persistence and adaptability knowing when to stay committed to a plan and when to adjust it based on feedback and results. Ultimately, strong planning is evidence-based, adaptive, and focused on achieving long-term objectives.

Recall

1. What are the steps of the Rational Planning Model?

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2. How do you usually decide whether to continue following a plan or change it when results are not as expected?

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3. What is more challenging for you: sticking to a plan until it works, or adapting it when it is not effective? Why?

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4. Which of the following is NOT a type of scenario in Scenario Planning

- a. Best-case scenario b. Worst-case scenario c. Most likely scenario
d. Past scenario

5. True & False

A plan can fail even if it is well-designed, due to poor execution and lack of follow-up

- a. True b. false

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